

writers,¹ ascended the throne and assumed the impossible burden of sustaining the vast empire which a great political and military genius had built up. The one event of his reign which has survived in the memory of man is preserved by the Hebrews alone.² He set Jehoiachin free—an act which indicates a policy directly opposed to that of his father. With this accords perfectly the reference of Berossos, who says that he ruled unlawfully and tyrannically.³ He was assassinated and his brother-in-law, Nergal-shar-usur (i. e., “Nergal protect the king,” Gr., *Neriglissor*), became king. He seems to have endeavored to follow closely the example of Nebuchadrezzar, whose daughter was his queen, and his inscriptions even imitate the phraseology of his great exemplar. He devoted himself largely to building and to restoration. Of the outer and larger politics of his reign we have only the hint that the relations of Babylon to Media were strained, and that the Medes pressed into the northern part of the valley and took Harran.

In 556 Nergal-shar-usur died, and his son, Labashi-Marduk, while still a youth, came to the throne. He was assassinated after but nine months of a precarious tenure of the throne, tradition alleging that he had displayed evil traits of character.⁴ We may perhaps discern in this simply an excuse to justify his violent removal as a part of a priestly plot to win the throne. The supposition finds a justification in the appearance as king, not of a Chaldean, but of a man of Babylonian origin, Nabonidus, whose whole reign is a continuous manifestation of interest in all things priestly and religious.

¹ 2 Kings 25. 27–30.

² See passage just cited.

³ ἀνόμως και ἀσελγώς. Berossos, in Eusebi Chronicorum Liber Prior, ed. Alfred Schoene, col. 50.

⁴ Says Berossus, διὰ τὸ πολλὰ ἐκφαίνειν κακότητα.